was a great morale booster for us.

As my baggage had arrived in Delhi from Algiers, I took some leave in May '91, to help my wife and daughter settle down in army accommodation at Pratap Chowk in Delhi Cantonment. When I returned from leave I was astonished to learn that my Brigade HQ had been ordered to move out of Anantnag, to be redeployed in a counterinfiltration posture. We had been given the operational responsibility of guarding the LoC of a newly created sector in Baramulla area and also to counter any infiltration or exfiltration from this sector. It was a strange decision to take away some of my original battalions and instead, to place under my operational command one infantry battalion and a BSF battalion. But what took the cake was that the annual confidential reports of the COs and other officers of these units were not to be initiated by me, but by their brigade commander sitting 40 kilometres away at Uri! To my mind, this was a perfect recipe for disaster as far as the functional efficiency of a formation was concerned. To make a commander responsible for an operational task on the LoC without having the power to seek accountability from his subordinates was certainly unreasonable, if not irrational. Unless one is given the authority to report on the operational performance of his subordinates, it becomes a herculean task to get the best out of them. I often wonder how I saved my goose from being cooked. Undeterred, I took up the challenge and managed to produce results, though it was extremely demanding on me, physically and mentally. At times, it felt as if I was playing with my life. Why, I cannot say! Had a streak of fatalism crept in?

'JJ, the next time you go for any cordon-and-search operation, I would like to come along. I have heard a lot about your address to the people and the "khopdi" (skull and bones) drill, and its impact on their minds,' said Major General Kevin D'Souza, the GOC of 19 Infantry Division. My response was a cryptic, 'Okay, Sir,' but I wondered how he came to know of it.